because he believes it does not serve America's interests. He intends to erect protectionist walls around America, which could well mark the beginning of the end of globalisation. Trump's prime target is China, but so is India, which he calls "the Tariff King". China has had a favourable trade balance with the US for long, which rankled Trump even during his first term. Even though he pushed China hard to set the imbalance right, it remains skewed in China's favour. Of the $575 billion worth of goods trade with the US in 2023, China enjoyed a favourable balance of $279 billion. Trump has vowed to impose an across-the-board hike of 60 per cent in tariffs on Chinese imports, which could result in the decoupling of the world's two largest economies.

And while he may claim to be "a true friend" of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, with a $35.3 billion trade surplus in India's favour, Trump is likely to impose a 10 per cent rise in tariffs on Indian exports to the US. India had a taste of this Trumpian resolve during the first term, when in 2019 he withdrew the preferential tariffs New Delhi enjoyed under America's Generalised System of Preferences (GSP) that covered $6.3 billion, or 12 per cent of the goods exported

TRUMP IS UNABASHED ABOUT HIS TRANSACTIONAL APPROACH TO KEY ISSUES. HE BELIEVES AMERICA'S DECLINE WAS BECAUSE IT ENDED UP PAYING EVERYONE ELSE'S BILLS

to the US. The tariffs on steel and aluminium exports also went up by 25 and 10 per cent, respectively. All India could do was retaliate, by imposing higher tariffs on 29 goods it imported from the US, including almonds, walnuts, chickpeas and apples. Many experts expect Trump to only be tougher in his second tenure. Mukesh Aghi, president of the US-India Strategic Partnership Forum (USISPF), warns, "Not just India and China, Trump is going to close the doors of America from the import perspective by putting in massive tariffs. There will also be lot of transactional uncertainty where there could be frequent changes in policy that could disrupt India's exports."

Some do spy an opportunity for India in Trump targeting trade with China, saying it could make Indian goods more competitive. Tellis is quick to curb that enthusiasm, saying he expects only a modest rise in exports on this count. "At the end of the day," he says, "India has neither

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EYE ON THE WHITE HOUSE

Key events in the tenures of US presidents since WW 2 and the highs and lows of their engagement with India



HARRY S. TRUMAN *(1945-1953)*

- The 'Truman Doctrine' sets US on new course, start of Cold War
- Desegregates military
- US involvement in Korean War (1950)

High: Food aid to India as it faces famine

Low: PM Jawaharlal Nehru's non-alignment policy during Cold War strikes a sour note

DWIGHT D. EISENHOWER *(1953-1961)*

- Korean War ends; anti-Communist South East Asian treaty Organisation (SEATO) established in 1953

High: First sitting US president to visit India (1960); economic aid; India seen as counter-balance against China

Low: Closer US ties with Pakistan as it joins Baghdad Pact, SEATO



JOHN F. KENNEDY *(1961-1963)*

- Bay of Pigs: Failed attempt at regime change in Cuba
- Cuban Missile Crisis resolved with USSR (1962)

High: Economic/ military aid during, after war with China; $1 billion aid for Third Plan

Low: Criticism of India's takeover of Goa through army action





LYNDON B. JOHNSON *(1963-1969)*

- Civil Rights Act of 1964 signed, outlawing discrimination based on race, colour, religion etc.
- Greater involvement in Vietnam War (1964-)

High: Support for Green Revolution; food aid continues, but in decreasing quantities

Low: Remains neutral in 1965 war with Pakistan